7.5 Raseborg Castle, Finland

Teija Tiitinen, Sari Mäntylä-Asplund

Location and surroundings

Raseborg (Finnish: Raasepori) Castle Ruins are located in the southernmost part of Finland on the coast of the Gulf of Finland. It is about 15 km to east of Tammisaari town and about 100 km southwest of Helsinki (Fig.25). The castle was built on a high rocky hill during a time when the place still was a small island. The island has now merged with the mainland due to post-glacial land uplift. The castle was in use for over two hundred years and during that time major changes both in the environment and landscape happened. It seems that at latest by the 16th century the castle was no longer reachable by large ships. One of the reasons why the castle was abandoned was the loss of its good position near the waterways. Nowadays the castle is surrounded by fields, meadows, and grazing lands. On the southern side of the castle there is the Raseborgså river. Less than a kilometre away to the north there is the Snappertuna hamlet and chapel.

Description of the site

Raseborg castle founded in the 1370s was the administrative, military, and economical centre of Western Uusimaa in the late Middle Ages. The castle and its castellan controlled a province consisting of eight parishes. The founding of the castle took place when Western Uusimaa was transferred under the control of Bo Josson Grip the Chief Justice of Sweden (Finland was a part of Sweden till the year 1812, forming the eastern part of the kingdom). The main purpose for the foundation of the castle was to form a strong fortress which guarded the Gulf of Finland and the coast of southern Finland.

Raseborg castle was built in stages. The main castle is joined by two outer castles. It consists of a ring wall with towers at the north and southwest ends (Fig.26). In the 15th century, a rectangular courtyard was formed in the main castle, when series of rooms were built on its east and west sides. At the same time, the horseshoe shaped perimeter wall was doubled and covered with brick. In the 1470s, a round tower was built in the southeast corner. At the beginning of the 15th century at the latest, the castle was surrounded by an underwater piling system, which was built to restrict the landing of the ships in front of the castle walls.

In 1540, King Gustaf Vasa set Raseborg castle under the direct administration of the crown. In those days the castle was in bad condition, and it had lost much of its former importance. Ten years later, the administrative centre was transferred to Helsinki, where a new royal manor, as well as a town, were founded in 1550. Some years later, the old castle was abandoned and was never settled again.

On the eastern and northeastern side of the castle there is a field called Bastuåkern (Fig.27). In test excavations, foundations of buildings and an ancient channel filled with clay and mud layers have been found. The material that has been found in the area consists mostly of imported goods. The interpretation is that a trading area was located there in the late medieval ages.

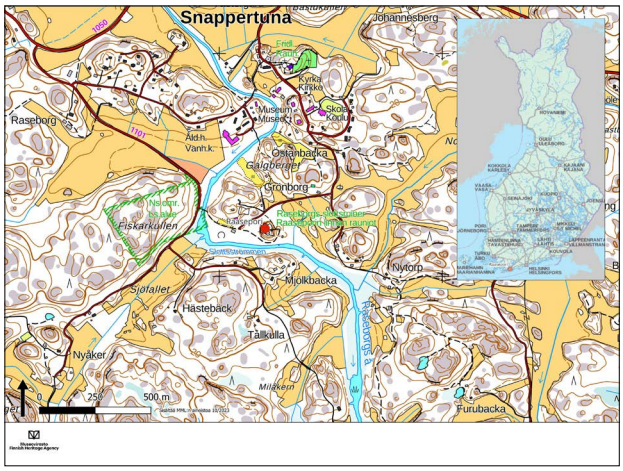

Figure 25: Location map. The Finnish Heritage Agency

Figure 26: Aerial photo of the area. Photo Vesa Laulumaa, The Finnish Heritage Agency

Figure 27: Bastuåkern was the place were among other things trade happened. It has been abandoned since the beginning of the 16th century and never habited again. Since that it has mainly been used as a grazing area. (Sari Mäntylä, The Finnish Heritage Agency).

Reasons for assessment

Raseborg castle was assessed as part of the Nationally Significant Archaeological Sites in Finland project (VARK) in 2022 (see section 6.3). Raseborg castle is one of eight medieval stone castles in Finland. All the castles from the Middle Ages are situated in the southernmost part of Finland. They were evaluated during the VARK project and all of them have been assessed as nationally significant sites. Raseborg castle is a special case among the castles in Finland because its surroundings have been very well preserved. All the other castles are situated in such places where the modern land use has destroyed at least some parts of their outer yards' area. The outer yard was the place where all the activity – excluding defence and administration – connected to the castle happened. This included activities like handcrafting, iron smithing and trade.

The assessment of Raseborg castle became necessary also due to the disturbance of the area in 2017. Almost three hundred pits had been made in the vicinity of the castle in spots which had been located by metal detectors. The incident led to a court hearing and a verdict was given in 2020.

Assessing significance—methods

In the beginning of the VARK-project, the criteria for assessing the significance of archaeological sites were created. All the sites were assessed by:

1. cultural-historical significance;
2. archaeological research value;
3. prevalence or rarity;
4. archaeological diversity;
5. environment and landscape; and
6. preservation of the area.

Figure 28: Raseborg castle seen from the north. It was surrounded by the sea until the beginning of the 16th century. Photo Sari Mäntylä, The Finnish Heritage Agency

Figure 29: The Raseborså river was the only way to reach the castle by boat. Photo Sari Mäntylä, The Finnish Heritage Agency

The evaluation of the objects also included scoring. The evaluation scale varied between 0-2 points or 1-3 points depending on the criteria. A site may thus have received a total of 1-17 points for its archaeological importance. If there were many items of the same type with the same score in the selection phase, some other variables were also considered. For example, if the archaeological site was in a nationally significant landscape area or a nationally significant building heritage area, the site's location might have added to the value of the site. The intention of the inventory is that sites with a nationally significant VARK-status will be preserved in all circumstances in the future and permits to disturb the site will no longer be given (see Section 6.3). However, if a permit is granted, there must be exceptionally good justification for it.

The assessment of the Raseborg area

Cultural-historic significance

Raseborg castle and its surroundings are very significant in terms of cultural history. Its establishment and use are directly linked to Finland's political history and the development of defence strategy in medieval Finland. It is also directly connected to the formation and development of society and its structure.

Score: 3 The area has great cultural-historic significance.

Research value

Archaeological excavations in the area have been carried out since 1890. Regardless of that, the castle and its surroundings still have great research potential. In the beginning, archaeological research was done as part of restoration work that has been going on since the end of the 19th century. Both restoration and research are still going on. Raseborg castle has also played a key role in the development of restoration methods in Finland. Despite several excavations and criminal activities by amateur metal detectorists, the site still has great research potential.

Score: 3 The area has significant research potential.

Prevalence or rarity

The whole area and the type of the archaeological site is very rare for Finland. There are only a few medieval stone castles in Finland and compared to the other castles the surroundings of Raseborg castle have been exceptionally well preserved. Because it was abandoned in the late medieval ages it was preserved from later activity and heavy modern land use. This means it is a rarity in Finland.

Score: 3 The site is very rare.

Archaeological diversity

Raseborg castle and the outer yard which are essentially related to each other are both relatively versatile both in their structures and their findings. Together they are corresponding to a medieval city in their nature.

Score: 3 High degree of diversity.

Environment and landscape

The landscape around the castle is relatively well preserved even though the castle has been a part of the continent for centuries, unlike during the time when it was built. At the beginning of the 14th century, the area still was an island but there still are such elements in the environment which support the understanding of the site and why the castle was built exactly there.

Score: 2 There still are ancient features in the environment and the landscape (Figs.28 & 29).

Degree of preservation

The Raseborg area is known for its well-preserved outer yards which were abandoned already during the late medieval period and never habited again. Severe damage to the area was done in 2017 when amateur metal detectorists dug almost three hundred pits there, but luckily most of the structures remained untouched. Otherwise, it has remained much in the same condition in which it was abandoned almost five hundred years ago. The surroundings of the castle have never been cultivated because the stoniness of the ground. Instead of that, the area has been grazed which has kept the area pretty much open.

Score: 2 Fairly well preserved

Raseborg castle received 16 points out of 17 in the assessment. There were several reasons why it was selected to the collection of nationally significant archaeological sites. The site is a unique example in Finland of a well-preserved medieval stone castle and with an outer yard. Together they form a rare and significant whole. Even though there have been numerous archaeological excavations during the 1800-1900 centuries, there are still large areas that have not been excavated or otherwise damaged. Its archaeological value is unique in Finland. In the evaluation also the fact that it is located in the area of a nationally significant built cultural heritage site and in a Nationally Valuable Landscape Area has been taken to account.